

6.2.7 Drivers

All hardware have a corresponding software that enables it to talk to the operating system, and through the operating system to other application software and/or devices. For example, printer driver software enables the printer to communicate with the operating system. Hence, when another application wants to print, it will “ask” the operating system, which will in turn connect it to the printer using the printer driver.

6.2.8 Installer

This is a software program that installs applications and other software onto your computer system. A typical application program may require many specific supporting system files before it can run properly. Programmers use the installer software to package all these files together. Depending on the size of the application, this could be a single file containing all the required data to complete the installation of the application software. The primary goal of installer programs is to hide the complexity of the installation process and to reduce the entire process to a point and click operation that can be used by any person whose knowledge of computer systems is minimal.

6.2.9 Open Source

Generally, open source refers to applications whose source code is available for any one to see and modify in any way they please. In general practice, over the last thirty to forty years since the birth of the software industry, software code has been considered to be the property of the organisation who designed the software, and anyone who used it was required to pay a license fee for using the software. In the early 1970s, Richard Stallman, a researcher at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, took an ideological stand against the use of proprietary software declaring that the right to read and modify the source code is a fundamental right and that software should be open and free: “Free as in free speech, not free beer.” He came up with the General Public License (GPL) for open source software. The GPL essentially states that anyone who receives a copy of any software covered